approaches. The first was to ‘question the unquestioned’ and the second to benchmark to the ‘best globally, rather than their own past history’.

The products and services of TELCO were to be ‘globally competitive’ and the ‘enterprises [should] operate to international standards in terms of quality and customer service’, he said. To achieve this, he called for a complete change in the attitude of the leadership and employees. ‘We will need to be extremely aggressive in the marketplace and much more proactive than we have been in the past in order to be leaders in our fields of business. We need a change of mindsets that break with past tradition in welcoming rather than resisting change,’ he said.

In an interview he explained: ‘We are going to look at our costs and margins on the same basis that the best would do, and we would keep on trying to measure against that.’ He reiterated, ‘We’re obviously not going to get there tomorrow but our moves will be those kind of moves rather than small deltas of improvement.’

He then turned his attention to TELCO’s CVBU, the bread and butter of the company. The main reforms that he had introduced in it were components of the JRD QV/TBEM programme. When the assessment was initially made under the programme, the performance of the business unit was judged as unimpressive. It was only able to score in the region of 40 per cent in the initial years, underscoring the need for immediate reforms. The excellence model threw up the strengths and weaknesses of the various segments of the unit. After their identification, it successfully resolved the issues and fast-tracked reforms that made CVBU the third winner of the JRD QV Award in 2005.

In 1995, Ratan had fixed an ambitious target for the automobile major: a turnover of Rs 20,000 crore to be achieved in the next five years. The standalone revenue of TELCO in 1995 was just over Rs 5,000 crore. The new target sounded more optimistic than realistic, as it excluded revenue from JVs.

Increasing exports was an integral part of Ratan’s growth plan. The emphasis was not as much on earning revenues as it was on the consequential benefits that it would engender. The aim was deeper—to attain the capability to export would require the company to achieve substantial improvement in the quality of its products. As Ratan said, it would be the ‘best calibrator’ of ‘international competitiveness’. This strategy was further granulated to focus on penetrating the ‘more developed